An outreach of the LCMS Ministry to the Armed Forces

OPERATION BARNABAS

A network of care for all military-connected individuals



A practical path for your church

This guide was developed by The Lutheran Church—Missouri Synod (LCMS) Ministry to the Armed Forces (MAF) to help congregations care for military-connected individuals and families within their communities.

MAF supports LCMS military chaplains, service members, veterans, and their families through spiritual care, resources, and congregational outreach. Operation Barnabas extends this ministry into local communities by equipping congregations to provide meaningful care and support. **No military experience is needed to get involved—only a desire to serve and care for those connected to the military.**

This guide offers practical ideas and resources that can be adapted to the needs of your congregation and community.

For questions about this guide or Operation Barnabas, please contact **lcmschaps@lcms.org**.

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Understanding Operation Barnabas

What is Operation Barnabas?

Operation Barnabas is a Christ-centered network of care dedicated to supporting and encouraging our nation's military members, veterans, and their families through the love of Christ.

MISSION

To equip congregations to recognize, welcome, and care for military members, veterans, and their families—sharing Christ's love through practical support, Christian fellowship, and connection to the Church.

VISION

That every military-connected person lives in the hope and peace of God's love and mercy as revealed in the resurrection of Jesus Christ.

GOALS

1. **Care:** Support and encourage military members, veterans, and their families.
2. **Equip:** Train and assist congregations in caring for and reaching out to military-connected individuals and families in their churches and communities.
3. **Connect:** Serve as a resource and partner to organizations supporting military-connected individuals and families.



Christ-Centered Care

Christ's death and resurrection are the foundation of Operation Barnabas. We are saved by grace through faith, not by our works (Ephesians 2:8-10). Because Christ first loved us, we are called to share that love by caring for and serving our neighbors (1 John 4:19).

Operation Barnabas puts this faith into action by caring for military members, veterans, and their families. This may include sharing the hope of the Gospel, connecting individuals with pastoral care, providing meals or transportation, offering companionship, welcoming newcomers, and helping people find appropriate resources.

Pastors preach and teach God's Word, provide spiritual care, and administer the Sacrament according to Scripture and the Lutheran Confessions. Lay members serve through their own vocations, gifts, and opportunities.

Together, the congregation can be a place where military-connected people are known, welcomed, supported, and connected to Christ and His Church.

Why Barnabas?

Barnabas means "son of encouragement" (Acts 4:36). Like Barnabas, this ministry encourages Christians to walk alongside others in faith and love.

"He was a good man, full of the Holy Spirit and of faith" (Acts 11:24).

Getting to Know Your Military-Connected Neighbors

Who is Military-Connected?

Military-connected individuals include currently serving members of the Army, Marine Corps, Navy, Air Force, Space Force, and Coast Guard; National Guard and Reserve members; veterans and retirees; and their spouses, children, parents, caregivers, and surviving loved ones.

Unique Experiences and Challenges

Military life can bring experiences that may be unfamiliar to those outside the military community. These can include deployments and separations, frequent moves, changing schools and churches, irregular schedules, grief or loss, and transitions from military to civilian life. Every experience is different. Taking time to listen and build relationships can help your congregation better understand their needs and offer meaningful, Christ-centered care.

Building Relationships

You do not need military experience to connect with military-connected individuals and families. Start as you would with any neighbor: introduce yourself, ask questions, listen, and build relationships. Avoid making assumptions about their experiences or the support they may need. Simple questions like “Would you like to share your military connection?” or “How can our congregation support you and your family?” can open the door to more in-depth conversations.

Do you know who is military-connected in your congregation?

The first place to start is in your own congregation. Military connections are not always visible, and you may be surprised by how many are already part of your church family. The person sitting next to you on Sunday may be a veteran, serve in the National Guard or Reserve, have a loved one currently serving, care for a veteran, or have lost a loved one who served. Learning about these connections can open doors. Use **Tool A: Military-Connected Household Information Sheet** (Page 24) to help identify military-connected individuals and families within your congregation and learn how your church can better support them.

But we don’t have a military installation nearby...

Military-connected people live in communities everywhere, not just near military installations. Start with your own members and their relatives, then look for connections in your community. A county veterans service office, nearby college or university, veterans home, VA hospital or clinic, or a local veterans organization (American Legion, VFW, etc.) can help you learn more about the military-connected in your area and their specific needs.

Congregation or Chapter?

Operation Barnabas can take different forms depending on your congregation and community. An **Operation Barnabas Congregation** intentionally cares for military-connected people within the congregation and surrounding community. An **Operation Barnabas Chapter** does the same while also developing ongoing relationships with veteran organizations and other community partners. Both are active expressions of Operation Barnabas. The difference is not where they serve, but how they connect with and work with others in the community.

Area	Operation Barnabas Congregation	Operation Barnabas Chapter
Care	Provides intentional care and support to military-connected individuals and families.	Provides intentional care and support to military-connected individuals and families.
Ministry	Integrates care into congregational life and outreach.	Coordinates ministry through an organized team.
Connections	Connects with local resources as needed.	Builds ongoing community partnerships.
Reach	Reaches people through congregational and community outreach.	Expands reach through veteran organizations and partnerships.

Operation Barnabas Congregation Example

Grace Lutheran Church has several military-connected members and families within its congregation. Through Operation Barnabas, members make an intentional effort to recognize and support them. The congregation includes military families in its prayers, recognizes veterans on Veterans Day, sends cards and care packages to deployed service members, and offers encouragement to families during deployments.

Operation Barnabas Chapter Example

Zion Lutheran Church supports military-connected members and families within its congregation while also extending its outreach into the surrounding community. Through its Operation Barnabas chapter, members build relationships with local veterans organizations, the county veterans service office, and a nearby veterans home. These partnerships help identify opportunities to serve beyond the congregation. Members may visit veterans in care facilities, provide transportation to appointments, assist with community veterans events, or organize service projects.

Your Road Map to Getting Started



Make It Official

Once your congregation is ready to join the Operation Barnabas network, complete **Tool B: Operation Barnabas Registration Form** (Page 25) and send to MAF. Once received, your congregation will be added to the roster and receive a certificate recognizing your participation.

1 - Pray

Ask God to guide your congregation, open doors for ministry, and help you recognize the military-connected people He has placed in your community.

2 - Talk

Share your interest in Operation Barnabas with your pastor. Discuss how military ministry can complement the congregation's existing ministries and outreach.

3 - Discover

Find out who is military-connected in your church family. Listen to their experiences and learn from their knowledge of the military and veteran community.

4 - Gather

Invite members who have an interest in military ministry to participate. Look for people with a heart to serve and a variety of gifts, skills, and community connections.

5 - Assess

Consider the resources already available to you—people, facilities, programs, professional skills, transportation, childcare, meals, and other gifts that could support military-connected individuals.

6 - Connect

Get to know organizations already serving military members, veterans, and families. Your county veterans service office, nearby military units, colleges, veteran homes, and other community partners can help you better understand needs.

7 - Serve

Start with one or two opportunities that match the needs you have discovered and the gifts of your congregation. This could be visiting veterans, supporting the family of a deployed member, hosting Bible studies, or providing meeting space.

Start small.

Build relationships.

Grow from there.

Walking Alongside Your Neighbors

Military life brings different seasons and opportunities for Christian care. Listen, ask what would be helpful, and walk alongside individuals and families in ways that fit their circumstances.

Entering Military Service

Leaving for basic training, officer training, or a military academy can bring excitement and uncertainty.

Your Congregation Can:

Pray for the service member and family; use a military sending service (**Tool C**); provide a Bible, Small Catechism, or devotional; place them on the Ministry-by-Mail list; and help connect them to MAF and an LCMS chaplain.

Moving to a New Community

Frequent moves can mean starting over with a church, school, and support system.

Your Congregation Can:

Welcome new arrivals and introduce them to members and help departing families find an LCMS congregation near their new location.

Deployment & Family Separation

Deployment, training, and temporary duty may separate individuals from family and the congregation.

Your Congregation Can:

Stay in touch and send cards or care packages (**Tool D**); remember important milestones; and ask family members whether meals, transportation, or home and yard help would be useful.

Transitioning from Service

Leaving the military may bring changes in work, relationships, routines, and identity.

Your Congregation Can:

Offer fellowship, opportunities to use their gifts, and practical help. Connect them with community and veteran resources when needed.

Homecoming & Reintegration

Coming home is joyful, but returning to everyday routines may take time.

Your Congregation Can:

Welcome them home without putting them on the spot; continue supporting the whole family; invite them into worship and fellowship; and give them the time and space they need to rest, reconnect, and readjust to daily life.

Retirement & Later Life

Veterans remain part of the military-connected community long after their service ends.

Your Congregation Can:

Visit those who are homebound or in care facilities; offer transportation or companionship, and remember caregivers; and invite veterans to share when they choose.

Care for the Person

Two people with similar military experiences may have very different needs. Ask rather than assume.

Illness, Injury, Grief, & Loss

Difficult circumstances call for compassionate and dependable care.

Your Congregation Can:

Be present, listen, pray, and involve the pastor; offer practical help and connect people with qualified resources when needs extend beyond congregational care.

A Place to Hear, Receive, and Belong

At the heart of Operation Barnabas is Christ's love for our military-connected neighbors. Through relationships and practical care, congregations can invite people to hear God's Word, receive pastoral care, and become part of the life of the Church.

Welcome Them into Congregational Life

Offer a personal invitation to worship, Bible study, or fellowship. Explain where to go and what to expect, introduce them to others, and offer to sit with them. Learn their names and welcome them again when they return.

Send Them with Prayer and Support

Before someone leaves for basic training, officer training, a military academy, or a deployment, arrange a military sending service with the pastor (**Tool C**). Pray for the individual and their family, provide spiritual resources, and agree to stay in touch.

Make Room for Military Schedules

Drill weekends, shift work, training, and deployments can interrupt regular attendance. Stay in touch and ask how the congregation can help them remain connected. Your pastor can discuss opportunities for spiritual care when they cannot attend.

Help Them Find a Church or LCMS Chaplain

When a service member or family moves, help locate an LCMS congregation near the new community. Contact MAF for help connecting with an LCMS military chaplain where available. With permission, help make the introduction rather than simply handing over a name.

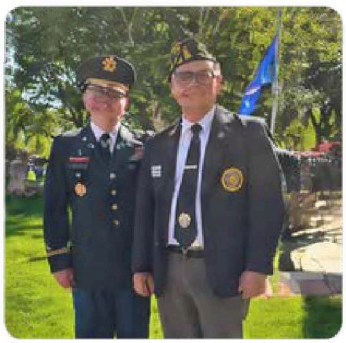
Connect with Your Pastor

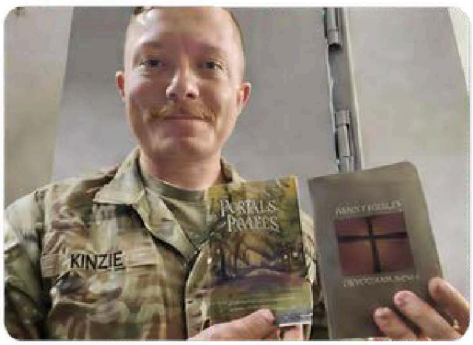
Let people know that the pastor is available for prayer, conversation, instruction, and spiritual care. With their permission, help arrange an introduction or visit. Questions about Baptism, Holy Communion, and church membership belong with the pastor or elders.

Keep Them Connected While Away

Ask about Ministry-by-Mail and other MAF resources for service members whose duties or location make congregational participation difficult. Cards, prayers, and regular contact can also remind them that their church family remembers and cares for them.







Resources for Your Congregation

LCMS Ministry to the Armed Forces (MAF) offers resources to help congregations care for military-connected individuals and keep service members connected to Christ and His Church.

Armed Forces Ministry Book

Published by CPH, the Armed Forces Ministry Book provides worship, devotional, and pastoral care resources for service members and their families. It includes prayer, Scripture readings, hymns, Luther's Small Catechism, and rites for pastoral use. It addresses deployment, trauma, grief, illness, moral injury, and family concerns.

Military Sending Service

A military sending service is a worship resource for pastors to use when someone leaves for military service. It provides an opportunity for the congregation to pray for the individual and family, commend them to God's care, and affirm their continued connection to the church.

Ministry-by-Mail

Ministry-by-Mail provides Lutheran service members with spiritual resources delivered by mail anywhere in the world. Participants receive an initial resource packet, followed by regular copies of the Portals of Prayer and So Help Me God newsletter.

Connect with an LCMS Chaplain

MAF helps service members and families connect with LCMS military chaplains where available. These chaplains provide spiritual care through God's Word, the Sacraments, prayer, and pastoral counsel in military settings.

MAF Veteran Pins

MAF Pins (the MAF logo) are given to veterans as a token of appreciation for their military service. They provide a simple, meaningful way for congregations to acknowledge and thank veterans in their church and community.

MAF Sunday Bulletin Inserts

These inserts introduce MAF's ministry and help congregations observe MAF Sunday (day after Armed Forces Day). Available materials include general ministry inserts in color or black and white, along with an insert featuring a responsive prayer and Ministry-by-Mail information.

Adopt-a-Chap Program

Adopt-a-Chap connects LCMS congregations with LCMS military chaplains through an ongoing relationship of prayer and encouragement. Participants support chaplains through regular communication and learn about their ministry to service members and families.

Congregations Supporting Military Bases

This list identifies LCMS congregations that support nearby military installations. It helps service members and families locate a church connection near their assignment and helps home congregations support members who are relocating.

More Resources for Your Congregation

Veterans Certificates

Veterans certificates recognize the military service of individuals within the congregation and community. The editable certificate allows congregations to personalize the recognition for each veteran.

Military Devotionals

Military devotionals provide Scripture, prayer, and Christian encouragement for those serving in the armed forces. These portable resources support personal devotion during training, deployment, and everyday military life.

LHM Bible Studies

Warriors in Faith - Military Men is a LHM Bible study written for service members and veterans. It explores anger, grief, guilt, forgiveness, and love in relation to military experiences, pointing participants to their vocation and lasting hope in Jesus Christ.

So Help Me God Newsletter

So Help Me God is MAF's quarterly newsletter for service members. It provides spiritual encouragement and updates from MAF and is mailed to participants in the Ministry-by-Mail program.

LHM Bible Studies (Cont.)

Called to Serve: Utilizing Our Gifts as Veterans is a five-session small group Bible study for veterans. Together, veterans join to discover their gifts, learn how to grow their gifts, and make a plan for sharing their gifts as a group and in their individual lives.

Warning Order Newsletter

Warning Order is a quarterly, online-only Operation Barnabas newsletter. It shares ministry ideas, resources, and updates to encourage local outreach and congregational care.

Portals of Prayer

Portals of Prayer is a devotional publication containing daily Scripture readings, devotions, and prayer. It offers a regular pattern of time in God's Word for service members, veterans, and families, whether home or away. Large print editions are also available.

Looking for Something Else?

Don't see what you're looking for? Ministry to the Armed Forces is here to help! Contact us for additional resources, materials, or ideas to support your congregation's ministry to military-connected individuals and families.

Know Your Community Resources

Your congregation can offer Christian care while helping military-connected individuals find assistance for needs beyond its resources. Knowing whom to contact makes it easier to offer a helpful connection.

County or State Veterans Service Office

Veterans service officers help veterans and families understand benefits and find assistance. Accredited representatives can help with VA benefits claims. Identify the office serving your county or state.

Military & Family Support Services

Military installations, National Guard and Reserve units, and Military OneSource connect service members and families with support for deployment, relocation, employment, finances, and family concerns.

Department of Veterans Affairs (VA)

VA medical centers and clinics provide healthcare for eligible veterans. VA also administers benefits related to education, disability, housing, and burial. Connect people with VA or an accredited representative for eligibility guidance.

Local Veteran Organizations

American Legion posts, VFW posts, and other veteran organizations may offer fellowship, service opportunities, and local assistance. Learn what each organization provides and identify a reliable contact.

Vet Centers

Vet centers offer readjustment counseling for eligible veterans, service members, and families. Services may include individual, group, and family counseling and connections to other resources.

Community Care & Support

Food pantries, transportation programs, employment services, caregiver organizations, and housing agencies can help meet practical needs.

Make a Helpful Connection

Ask what help the person wants. Confirm services, eligibility, and contact information. With permission, help make the initial call or introduction, then follow up.

Keep a Local Resource List

Record each organization's name, services, contact person, phone number, eligibility requirements, and date verified. Keep the list accessible to your pastor and designated ministry volunteers, and review it regularly.

Ideas for Connecting and Caring

The following pages feature events and activities that Operation Barnabas congregations have successfully offered to care for military-connected individuals and families. Whether you are beginning your ministry or looking for new ways to serve, these examples may help guide you.

Consider what individuals would welcome and the gifts your congregation can share. Adapt the ideas to your community, available volunteers, and resources. From prayer to fellowship to recognition and practical support, each activity offers an opportunity to build relationships and share Christ's love.

MAF is always ready to assist your congregation with ideas, resources, and guidance. If you have held an event or have another activity you would like to see added to this list, please contact MAF. Your ideas can encourage other congregations in their care for military-connected individuals.

We would love to see your ministry in action! Share photos and a brief description of your events with MAF at lcmschaps@lcms.org so we can highlight your congregation's outreach in our newsletters and on social media. Please confirm that those pictured have given permission for their photos to be shared.

1 Pray for the Military

Include prayers for service members, deploying units, veterans, families, and caregivers during worship or through a prayer chain. Invite people to submit names and requests, and ask what they are comfortable sharing.

What you'll need: Names and prayer requests, permission to share, and someone to keep requests updated.







2 Design a Military Challenge Coin

Military challenge coins are a valued tradition in the military community. Design one featuring your church's name and a Christian message or symbol, and present it to service members and veteran newcomers as a personal welcome. Pair it with an invitation to worship or fellowship and a reminder that your congregation cares for them.

What you'll need: A coin design, a manufacturer, funding, and members to welcome newcomers and present the coin.



3 Morning Muster (Coffee/Donuts)

Invite service members, veterans, and their families for coffee, donuts, and casual conversation. Hold it after worship or on a Saturday morning. A few friendly hosts can help introduce people and make everyone feel welcome.

What you'll need: A gathering space, coffee, donuts, basic serving supplies, and members to welcome guests.





4 Celebrate MAF Sunday

MAF Sunday is typically celebrated on the Sunday after Armed Forces Day, but congregations may celebrate it on any Sunday throughout the year. Give thanks for service members, veterans, chaplains, and their families through prayers during worship, MAF bulletin inserts, and opportunities to learn about military ministry.

What you'll need: Your pastor's involvement, MAF Worship resources and bulletin inserts, and members to help share information and welcome guests.



5 Military Sending Service

When someone leaves for basic training, officer training, a military academy, or deployment, surround them with the congregation's prayers. A military sending service commends them to God's care and reminds them and their family that their church will remain connected while they are away.

What you'll need: Your pastor's involvement, MAF's sending service resource (**Tool C**), the individual's agreement to participate, and someone to coordinate ongoing contact.



6 Visit a Veterans Home

Arrange visits to a local veterans home or care facility. Spend time talking, reading, playing games, or participating in an activity suggested by staff. Regular visits can help relationships grow and remind residents that they are remembered.

What you'll need: A facility contact, volunteers who enjoy visiting, any required orientation, and staff-approved activity supplies.





7 Deployment Meal Train

Provide meals for a military family during deployments and family separations. Ask what would be helpful, then invite members to prepare or purchase meals on an agreed schedule.

What you'll need: A coordinator, meal volunteers, the family's dietary preferences, and a delivery schedule.



8 Cards & Care Packages

Send encouragement to deployed service members or veterans in a VA facility through handwritten cards and requested supplies. Use MAF's care package supplies list (**Tool D**) to guide donations, and confirm what recipients can receive before collecting or sending items. Invite children, youth, and adults to participate. MAF can supply addresses to deployed chaplains when available.

What you'll need: MAF's care package supplies list (**Tool D**), a verified recipient or facility contact, cards, requested items, packing supplies, and postage or delivery arrangements.







9 Veterans Day Recognition Display

Create a display for Veterans Day that recognizes veterans in your congregation and community. Include photographs, names, branches of service, and brief stories they choose to share. The display offers a way to thank veterans, learn about their service, and remember them in prayer.

What you'll need: A display space, photographs and service information, permission to share, labels, decorations, and volunteers to assemble the display.





10 Build an Honor Wall

Create a permanent display recognizing service members and veterans connected to your congregation. Include photographs, names, branches of service, and brief information they choose to share. Invite members to stop, learn about their neighbors, and remember them in prayer.

What you'll need: An approved display space, copies of photographs, permission to share information, labels, and someone to maintain the display.







11 POW/MIA Remembrance Table

Set up a remembrance table to honor prisoners of war and those missing in action. Include a brief explanation of the table's symbols so visitors can understand its meaning (**Tool E**). Display it during Memorial Day, POW/MIA Remembrance Day, Veterans Day, a recognition dinner, or another appropriate occasion.

What you'll need: A small round table, white tablecloth, empty chair, place setting, and symbolic items such as a red rose, yellow ribbon, candle, lemon, and salt, along with an explanation of their meaning.





12 Help with Childcare

Offer childcare to give a military parent or caregiver time for an appointment, errands, or rest. Use your congregation's established childcare procedures and ask the family what support would be most helpful.

What you'll need: Church approval, screened and trained caregivers, appropriate staffing, a safe space, parent permission, and emergency contact information.





13 Hold a Veteran Stand Down

Work with local VA staff, veteran organizations, and community agencies to host a Stand Down for veterans experiencing or at risk for homelessness. Bring meals, clothing, housing assistance, healthcare connections, and benefits guidance together in one place. Provide care bags filled with requested items, such as socks and toiletries, along with personal notes of encouragement and devotions.

What you'll need: Community partners, a planning team, an accessible location, volunteers, qualified service providers, and an organizer-approved supplies list.







14 Hold a Meal or Picnic

Host a dinner or picnic recognizing veterans, service members, and their families. Share a meal, offer a brief expression of thanks, and leave plenty of time for conversation. MAF pins or personalized certificates can add a meaningful touch.

What you'll need: A gathering space, a meal team, invitations, serving supplies, welcoming volunteers, and optional pins or certificates.





15 Deployment Yard Help

Offer yard care for a military family while their service member is deployed. Volunteers can mow, rake leaves, shovel snow, or help with other seasonal tasks. Ask the family what would be helpful and arrange a schedule that works for them.

What you'll need: Willing volunteers, appropriate yard tools, the family's permission, and a schedule for ongoing help.







16 Present MAF Pin or Certificate

Thank veterans in your congregation and community by presenting a MAF pin or personalized veteran certificate. Offer the recognition during a church gathering, Veterans Day event, or personal visit.

What you'll need: MAF pins or veteran certificates, a printer for certificates, names for personalized certificates, and someone to make the presentation.



17 Exhibit at a Local Event

Set up a welcoming booth at a community fair, veterans event, or other local gathering. Introduce Operation Barnabas, connect with military-connected neighbors, and invite them to your congregation. MAF can supply a tablecloth, banner, resources, and giveaways for your exhibit.

What you'll need: Event organizer's permission, a table, chairs, church invitations, and volunteers to work the booth. Contact MAF to arrange exhibit materials.





Military Observances

Use these observances to plan prayers, recognition, and care for military-connected individuals and families throughout the year.

February

(*Feb 3*) Four Chaplains Day
(*Feb 19*) Coast Guard Reserve Birthday

March

(*Mar 3*) Navy Reserve Birthday
(*Mar 13*) K-9 Veterans Day
(*Mar 25*) National Medal of Honor Day
(*Mar 29*) National Vietnam War Veterans Day

April

(*Apr 5*) Gold Star Spouses Day
(*Apr 14*) Air Force Reserve Birthday
(*Apr 24*) Army Reserve Birthday

May

(*May 1*) Silver Star Banner Day
(*Friday before Mother's Day*) Military Spouse Appreciation Day
(*May 13*) Children of Fallen Patriots Day
(*Third Saturday*) Armed Forces Day
(*Day after Armed Forces Day*) MAF Sunday
(*Last Monday*) Memorial Day

June

(*Jun 6*) D-Day Anniversary
(*Jun 14*) Flag Day and Army Birthday
(*Jun 23*) Coast Guard Auxiliary Birthday
(*Jun 27*) National PTSD Awareness Day

July

(*Jul 4*) Independence Day
(*Jul 27*) Korean War Veterans Armistice Day

August

(*Aug 4*) Coast Guard Birthday
(*Aug 7*) Purple Heart Day
(*Aug 29*) Marine Corps Reserve Birthday

September

(*Sep 11*) Patriot Day
(*Sep 18*) Air Force Birthday
(*Third Friday*) National POW/MIA Recognition Day
(*Last Sunday*) Gold Star Mother's and Family's Day

October

(*Oct 13*) Navy Birthday
(*Oct 26*) National Day of the Deployed

November

(*Nov 10*) Marine Corps Birthday
(*Nov 11*) Veterans Day

December

(*Dec 1*) Civil Air Patrol Birthday
(*Dec 7*) National Pearl Harbor Remembrance Day
(*Dec 13*) National Guard Birthday
(*Dec 20*) Space Force Birthday

Month-Long Observances

April: Month of the Military Child
May: National Military Appreciation Month
May: Month of the Military Caregiver
November: Military Family Month
November: Warrior Care Month

Additional Contacts

These contacts are provided to help congregations better understand and respond to the needs of military-connected individuals and families. Congregations are encouraged to build relationships with local veteran service offices, military installations, and community organizations to identify additional support available in their area.

Resource	Link	Information
LCMS Ministry to the Armed Forces	https://www.lcms.org/who-we-are/national-mission/ministry-to-the-armed-forces	Ministry resources, devotionals, and support.
LCMS Operation Barnabas	https://www.lcms.org/ministry-to-the-armed-forces/operation-barnabas	Resources and sign up for the *Warning Order* newsletter.
Military OneSource	https://www.militaryonesource.mil/	Information about deployments, military family life, relocation, and available support services.
Department of Veterans Affairs (VA)	https://www.va.gov/	Veteran benefits, health care, disability services, and other assistance.
VA Accredited Representatives	https://www.va.gov/get-help-from-accredited-representative/	Helps veterans find qualified assistance with VA benefits and claims.
VA Facility Locator	https://www.va.gov/find-locations/	Locate VA medical centers, Vet Centers, and other VA services.
Elizabeth Dole Foundation	https://www.elizabethdolefoundation.org/	Resources for military and veteran caregivers and their families.
Veterans Crisis Line	https://www.veteranscrisisline.net/ or Dial 988 then Press 1	Confidential crisis support for veterans and service members.

Stay Connected with Ministry to the Armed Forces

The LCMS Ministry to the Armed Forces (MAF) is here to support your congregation as you care for military-connected individuals and families. Whether you have questions, need ministry resources, would like to arrange a training visit, or want to share the work your congregation is doing, we would love to hear from you!

Contact Us

Ministry to the Armed Forces
The Lutheran Church—Missouri Synod
1333 S. Kirkwood Road
St. Louis, MO 63122

Phone: (314) 996-1337
Email: lcmschaps@lcms.org

Follow Us on Social Media

Stay connected with Ministry to the Armed Forces for ministry updates, outreach ideas, stories from our chaplains, and examples of how congregations are serving military members, veterans, and their families.

Ministry to the Armed Forces Facebook: https://www.facebook.com/MinistryArmedForces.LCMS

Operation Barnabas Facebook: https://www.facebook.com/OperationBarnabasLCMS

Ministry to the Armed Forces Instagram: https://www.instagram.com/lcmsmaf/

Ministry to the Armed Forces X: https://x.com/LCMSMAF

Operation Barnabas X: https://x.com/opbarnabas

Share Your Ministry with Us!

We love hearing how congregations are putting Operation Barnabas into action! Send us photos, stories, and highlights from your events and outreach activities. Your congregation's efforts may be featured in our newsletters or on social media, helping inspire other congregations to serve their military-connected neighbors.

Email your stories and photos to: lcmschaps@lcms.org

Tool A: Military-Connected Household Information Sheet

Military-Connected Household Information Sheet

The Lutheran Church—Missouri Synod | Ministry to the Armed Forces

Getting to Know Our Military-Connected Families

Our congregation desires to recognize, encourage, and support those who serve, those who have served, and their families. This voluntary information sheet helps us get to know our military-connected households and identify opportunities to provide Christian care, fellowship, and encouragement.

Household Information

Name(s): _____

Address: _____

City: State: ZIP:

Phone: _____

Email: _____

Military Connection

Please check all that apply to your household:

☐ Active Duty Service Member ☐ Reserve Member ☐ National Guard Member

☐ Veteran ☐ Military Spouse or Family Member

Branch(es) of Service

Please check all that apply:

☐ Army ☐ Marine Corps ☐ Navy

☐ Air Force ☐ Space Force ☐ Coast Guard

Congregational Care

Is there any way our congregation can support or assist you or your family?

_____

_____

_____

Thank you for sharing a little about your household. This information will be used for congregational care and Operation Barnabas outreach and will not be shared outside the congregation without your permission.

Tool B: Operation Barnabas Registration Form

OPERATION BARNABAS

Congregation & Chapter Registration Form

The Lutheran Church—Missouri Synod | Ministry to the Armed Forces

Join the Operation Barnabas Network!

Operation Barnabas equips LCMS congregations to recognize, encourage, and care for military-connected individuals and families within their congregations and communities. By joining the network, your congregation becomes part of a ministry dedicated to sharing Christ's love with service members, veterans, and their families.

Congregation Information

Congregation Name: _____

Street Address: _____

City: _____ **State:** _____ **ZIP:** _____

LCMS District: _____

Congregation Phone: _____

Congregation Email: _____

Primary Point of Contact

Name: _____

Role/Position: _____

Email: _____

Phone: _____

Operation Barnabas Participation

We would like to register as:

☐ Operation Barnabas Congregation – Supporting military-connected individuals and families through congregational care and local outreach.

☐ Operation Barnabas Chapter – Expanding congregational outreach through partnerships with veteran organizations, community groups, and other local resources.

Additional Assistance

☐ We would like a representative from Ministry to the Armed Forces (MAF) to visit our congregation to provide Operation Barnabas training and guidance.

Please return your completed form to:

LCMS Ministry to the Armed Forces | lcmschaps@lcms.org

Thank you for helping us share Christ's love and encouragement with those who serve, those who have served, and their families.

Tool C: Military Sending Service

This rite is used to bid farewell and Godspeed to a member who is departing for service in the armed forces of our country. It also might be adapted for someone departing for employment in civilian industry overseas or some other endeavor that will separate him or her from the home congregation for an extended period of time.

Immediately before the Benediction in the Divine Service, the individual who is leaving comes before the altar. The pastor addresses the congregation with these or similar words:

[P] People of God in Christ, ***Name*** is entering the service of our country in the ***Branch of Service***. At this time of farewell and Godspeed, we look to the Word of our Lord for comfort, peace, and guidance.

"Bless the Lord, O my soul, and all that is within me, bless his holy name! Bless the Lord, O my soul, and forget not all his benefits. …God is our refuge and strength, a very present help in trouble. …The Lord of hosts is with us; the God of Jacob is our fortress. …Delight yourself in the Lord, and he will give you the desires of your heart" (Ps. 103:1-2; 46:1, 11; 37:4).

Glory be to the Father and to the Son and to the Holy Spirit; as it was in the beginning, is now, and will be forever. Amen.

Name, when you were baptized you began your vocation as a Christian. Through these years, God has blessed you with unique, special gifts and interests that have led you to service in the ***Branch of Service***. Today it is our privilege to affirm you as you represent our country. Let your Christian light shine wherever your military service may take you. Our ascended Lord assures you, "Lo, I am with you always." With His forgiveness and the constant presence of His Spirit, with all His grace and fatherly care, He is with you, ***Name***. We commend you and your family to His gracious care and pledge to you and your family our prayers and continued spiritual support.

Let us pray: O God, You called Abraham from his home and led him in safety on many journeys. Now, we pray, go with ***Name***, as he/she departs for service in our country's armed forces. Stretch forth Your almighty arm to strengthen and protect those who serve in the armed forces of our country. Support them in times of war and in times of peace. Keep them from all evil, giving them courage and loyalty, and grant that, in all things, they may serve honestly and without reproach; through Jesus Christ, our Lord. Amen.

Benediction.

Tool D: Care Packages

Care packages sent to deployed locations are greatly appreciated by service members. However, donors may not always be aware of the specific conditions and resource availability at these locations, which can result in items being discarded due to lack of need or damage from the climate.

Most deployed locations around the world have well-established infrastructure, including base exchanges where service members can purchase essential items. Shortages typically occur when service members are assigned to a new location with limited infrastructure (bare base), particularly at the start of a new operation. Additionally, many locations provide widespread internet connectivity, allowing service members to access the internet and use various apps to stay connected, which makes donations like phone cards unnecessary. Service members have access to fully stocked dining facilities (DFAC) offering a variety of meals. However, snacks and drink mixes are always appreciated, especially when operational duties prevent them from going to the DFAC.

Donors who send care packages often want to know if the items are well-received. To assist, we've provided a list of frequently requested items, as well as items that are unnecessary or harder to distribute. We also recommend including your name or your organization's name along with contact information, so service members have the opportunity to reply with a thank you.

Items frequently **REQUESTED** by service members

- **Snacks:** Individually packaged; Granola bars, trail mix, nuts, beef jerky, crackers, candy, Rice Krispies, etc.
- **Gum/Mints:** Especially "breath enhancers" when they can't always brush their teeth.
- **Drink Mixes:** Single-serve packets.
- **Wipes:** When showering is not possible.
- **Chapstick:** Especially in extreme hot or cold environments.
- **Decorations:** If sending boxes for Christmas or other holidays.
- **Devotionals/Crosses:** Offer spiritual encouragement.
- **Puzzle Books:** Word searches, crosswords, etc., for times when internet is down.
- **Personal Care Items in Small Quantities:** Shaving cream, razors, lotion, female hygiene products, etc.
- **Letters/Cards/Drawings:** These are absolutely adored.

Items **DIFFICULT** to give away to service members

- **Perishable Foods:** Items that require refrigeration or have a short shelf life, like fruit or dairy products.
- **Canned Foods:** No way to cook contents, unnecessary when there's a dining facility.
- **Condiment Packs:** Ketchup, mustard, etc., typically get thrown away.
- **Toilet Paper:** Facilities are properly stocked.
- **Personal Care Items in Excess:** Soap, toothpaste, deodorant, etc., are available at base exchanges.
- **Chocolate/Gummy Candy:** Arrives melted together in a glob.
- **Liquids:** Could spill or get damaged.
- **Items with Strong Odors:** Perfumes, lotions, etc., are not well-received in shared living spaces.
- **Phone Cards:** Not needed; most members just use video calling apps.
- **Books:** Highly dependent on preferences.

Tool E: POW/MIA Table Items and Meanings

Items Required:

- A small, round table
- A chair
- A dinner plate
- A bread plate
- Spoon, fork, and butter knife
- White tablecloth
- Black napkin
- Single red rose
- Vase
- Yellow ribbon
- Slice of lemon
- Salt
- Wine glass
- White candle
- Bible

The **table** is set for one. The **chair** is empty—they are not here.

The **table** is round to show our everlasting concern.

The **cloth** is white, symbolizing the purity of their intentions to respond to their country's call to arms. The **black napkin** represents the sorrow for those still missing.

The **single red rose** in a vase reminds us of the lives of these Americans and their loved ones and friends who keep the faith while seeking answers.

The **yellow ribbon** around the vase symbolizes our continued uncertainty, our hope for their return, and a demand for proper accounting of those who are not among us today.

A **slice of lemon** on the plate reminds us of their bitter fate, captured or missing in a foreign land while serving our country.

Grains of salt on the plate remind us of the countless fallen tears of families who continue to long for answers.

An **inverted glass** symbolizes their inability to share a toast.

The **lighted white candle** reflects hope that our missing will return someday.

The **Bible** represents the strength gained through faith to sustain us and those lost from our country, founded as one nation under God.

They are missing..... REMEMBER

